

Dave Gage's



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Basic Blues Improv [Blues Riffs]



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Simple blues [riffs](#) are perhaps the most common way for one to begin improvising on the harmonica. Use repetition of a single riff and pauses between these riffs to create a more melodic feeling to your playing. Sound files examples, explanations, and instruction are directly below the blues riffs.

***Please Note-** Our Free Site content includes many of the underlined links in the "gray navigation box" directly above; the other topics are available exclusively in the Members Area. Some links lead to lists of additional content also found in the Members Area.

The complete website with over "425 pages of info and instruction" is available with [Membership at Harmonica Lessons.com.](#)

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2nd position (G on C) 2nd Position Blues Riffs

<u>Trouble Riff</u> 4 5 4 5 6 ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↑	<u>Blues Riff #4</u> 6 5 4 5 6 ↑ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↑	<u>Mannish Boy Riff</u> 2 4 (3) 3 2 2 2 ↓ ↑ (↑) ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ opt.
<u>Blues Riff #1</u> 2 3 4 4 4 3 2 ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓	<u>Blues Riff #2</u> 1 2 2 3 2 ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↓	<u>"Almost" Blues Scale</u> 2 3 4 4 5 6 5 4 4 3 2 ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↑ ↓ ↓
<u>Blues Riff #3</u> 4 4 4 5 6 ↓ ↙ ↓ ↓ ↑ b	<u>Blues Riff #4 w/ bend</u> 2 2 1 2 2 ↓ ↙ ↓ ↙ ↓ bb bb	<u>Warble (trill)</u> 4 5 4 5 4 5 4 ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ etc.
<u>Triplet Riffs</u> 4 3 4 6 5 4 4 5 4 3 2 2 ↓ ↓ ↑ ↑ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↓ ↑ (Triplets: all three notes in one foot tap. Emphasize first note each time.)		

- **"Number and Arrow" system of notation**- The "up" arrows indicate blow (exhale) notes and the "down" arrows are for the draw (inhale) notes- The little "b's" under the bent arrows are [flat signs](#). One "b" is a [half step](#) bend and two "b's" are a whole step bend (as shown in the graphic below).

4 ↑ = Blow on Hole 4	4 ↓ = Draw (inhale) on Hole 4
3 ↙ = Whole step bend on Hole 3 bb	

The number and arrow system.

- **All riffs are played in the 2nd position**- For more information on 2nd position, visit the [General Overview](#) section.
- **Use your own timing**- Except for the [triplet riffs](#), you can use your own timing with these riffs to make them fit into whatever song you are playing with. Listen to the sound file below the riffs to help get you started.
- **For Intermediate and Advanced players**- you can add a 4 draw bend between the 4 blow and the 4 draw of the "Almost Blues Scale" riff. This will make it a complete one octave [blues scale](#).
- **"Jam-To" Blues MIDI File**- If you would like a quick, easy background song to begin jamming to, you can use the ["Jam-To" MIDI File](#) in "G" to try out the different riffs and ideas outlined here. Additional MIDI files are also available.
- **CDs to play along with**- You'll also want to take a look at the CDs: Song Keys section which contains a listing of albums with each track "keyed" so that you

will be able to jam to the songs found on it. Most of the CDs can be purchased via our [Store: Buy Music CDs page](#). Beginning jammers will find the ["Recommended for Beginners" CDs](#) page a great place to start.

Click here to learn about the ["Techniques Improv"](#) or ["Target Notes"](#) approach to jamming.

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